

AN ACADEMIC COMEBACK WORKBOOK

STAT SUCCESS

When your grade can't wait.

Failure is what happened.
It is not who you are.

Dr. Sharilyn Rennie

Professor of Anatomy & Physiology

Edition 2.0 · 2026

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AUTHOR

Dr. Sharilyn Rennie

Professor of Anatomy & Physiology

A LETTER FROM THE AUTHOR

You have not failed.

Something happened. That is not the same thing.

Failing a course is not who you are. It is what happened. Almost everyone who picks up a workbook like this is confusing the two. If you have been telling yourself you are a failure, or not smart enough, stop. That is the shame talking, and the shame is wrong about you.

Here is what is true. Your grade is data, not identity. A failing grade is fixable. Even the worst case, failing the class, is a recoverable loss. The only outcome that does not recover is giving up. As long as you are still in the work, the door is open.

I built STAT Success for the moment you are in. Most study programs are for students who are already steady and want a B to become an A. This is not that. It is a clinical method for an academic emergency. You will triage your own situation, find out what is actually going wrong, stabilize first, and come back one exam at a time.

The work is honest. It will ask you to look at numbers you have been avoiding. Do it anyway. None of it requires you to be exceptional. It requires you to be present. You are reading this, so you have not given up. That is enough to start.

SCAN TO USE ONLINE**Online companion tool hub**

Most worksheets here have a matching interactive tool online. Same content, auto-scored. Use the hub for the math, the book to keep your work.



SCAN FOR DIRECT ACCESS

Yours in the work,

Dr. Sharilyn Rennie

BEFORE THE WORK BEGINS

A note on failure.

Read this once. Then stop arguing with it.

The letter on the last page was the encouragement. This page is the mechanism, because the thing that ends most courses is not the failing grade. It is the story you build on top of it.

A grade is a number on a screen. The story turns that number into a verdict about who you are, and the verdict is what makes you stop showing up. You will feel the pull to write it. Everyone does. The skill is catching the slide from "I failed that exam" to "I am a failure" and stopping at the first one, because the first one is true and fixable and the second one is neither.

None of this means the grade does not matter. It does. That is exactly why you are going to work it instead of running from it. But you work a problem differently than you mourn a loss, and right now what you have is a problem.

THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

You can fail an exam, a quiz, even a whole course, and still not be a failure. One is an event. The other is a story you are choosing to tell. You can choose a different one.

Turn the page. The first real work is a clear-eyed look at the numbers.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to use this workbook.

An honest assessment, one repeatable method, and a plan for after.

This workbook gives you an honest read on where you are, one method you run exam by exam, and a plan for what comes next. You do it on your own, at your own pace.

A COMEBACK WORKBOOK, NOT A PREVENTION ONE

Working a course you are failing is not the same as working one you are starting fresh. A comeback is triage: narrow your focus, stop the worst of the bleeding, and let the low-value topics go for now. Staying healthy later is the opposite job, broad and steady. This book is built for the first. Once your grade is stable, the last part shows you how to switch back to the second.

Three things to know

Start with Part 1.

The diagnostic, the grade audit, and the decision flowchart are not optional. They tell you where to put your effort.

Write in this book.

It is fillable. Use a pencil if you want to revise. Honesty matters more than neatness.

Work one Stage per exam.

You can read the book in an afternoon. You cannot do the work in one. Run a Stage for each exam, and do not skip ahead.

The workbook map

PART 1 · Triage

Diagnose your acuity and your failure modes.

PART 2 · The Recall Toolbox

Six study techniques that actually move a grade.

PART 3 · The Stage

The repeatable loop you run for every exam.

CASE LIBRARY

Seven students, seven failure patterns.

PART 4 · After STAT

What to keep, and how to catch trouble early.

WHAT IS INSIDE

Contents.

PART ONE

Triage

7

Diagnose how urgent it is, and the specific reasons you are failing.

PART TWO

How to study

19

The Recall Toolbox: six techniques that actually move a grade.

PART THREE

The Stage

27

The repeatable loop you run for every exam in your course.

CASE LIBRARY

The seven cases

41

Seven students, seven failure patterns. Read the one that fits.

PART FOUR

After STAT

50

What to keep once your grade is stable, and how to catch trouble early.

PART ONE

Triage.

Do this once, before your first Stage.



PART 1 · HOW URGENT IS THIS

The three acuties.

Different situations call for different strategies. Find yours before you do anything else.

LEVEL 1

Stable

Who you are	Your grade is in the B range or better. More than four weeks until your next exam. You feel steady across most topics.
Strategy	Long-term mastery. Deep, deliberate practice across all your topics.
What to do	You may not need this workbook yet. Keep it in case a grade starts to slip.

LEVEL 2

Urgent

Who you are	Your grade is in the C range. Two to four weeks until your next exam. Low confidence in specific topics.
Strategy	Targeted work on your weak areas. Steady practice. Check your progress often.
What to do	This workbook is built for you. Work a full Stage for every exam ahead.

LEVEL 3

Critical

Who you are	Your grade is at or below passing. Less than two weeks until your next exam. Wide uncertainty.
Strategy	Stabilize first. Work your highest-value topics only. Accept partial coverage. Triage hard.
What to do	Start now. Make your nearest exam your first Stage, and keep your focus narrow.

PART 1 · WHERE YOU ACTUALLY ARE

Grade audit.

Fifteen minutes. Open your syllabus and your gradebook. Be honest, not aspirational.

Your course

Course name & number

Instructor

Current grade (%)

What grade do you need to pass?

What grade is your goal?

Weeks into the semester

Weeks remaining

Next major assessment & date

What is still left to earn?

List every remaining graded item. Be specific. This is the math of your comeback.

ASSIGNMENT / EXAM	WEIGHT (%)	DUE / DATE	TARGET SCORE

REALITY CHECK
Add the weights in column 2. If they total much less than 100% minus what is already locked in your current grade, your math is off. Recheck before continuing.

SCAN TO USE ONLINE

Grade weighting calculator (online)

Enter your remaining assignments and weights. The tool finds the score you need on each one to reach your goal. Copy those targets into the table above.



SCAN FOR DIRECT ACCESS

PART 1 · WHY YOU ARE FAILING, MORE SPECIFICALLY

Failure mode diagnostic.

24 statements. Four dimensions. About 8 to 10 minutes.

If you are failing a course, you are probably not failing for one reason. It is usually a particular mix, and your comeback depends on which parts of that mix are doing the most damage. This diagnostic looks at four dimensions and builds a profile that fits your situation, not a generic one.

How to answer

Rate each statement from 1 to 5. A 1 means not true of you right now. A 5 means deeply true right now. Rate how things are, not how you wish they were or plan to change them.

THE SCALE

- 1 Not true of you right now.
- 2 Slightly true.
- 3 Moderately true. About half the time.
- 4 Mostly true.
- 5 Deeply true right now.

THE PROFILE IS ONLY USEFUL IF YOUR ANSWERS ARE HONEST.

Fudge the answers and you slow your own comeback, because false data hides the very pattern you need to fix. Rate where you are, not where you want to be.

SCAN TO USE ONLINE

Failure Mode Diagnostic (online)

Take the 24 questions online and the tool scores you. Then bring your four subtotals back to the book and write them in.



SCAN FOR DIRECT ACCESS

PART 1 · DIMENSION · TIME

Time scarcity.

RATE EACH FROM 1 TO 5 1 = NOT TRUE 5 = DEEPLY TRUE

1. I run out of time to study before every major assessment.	1	2	3	4	5
2. Work, family, or health obligations take priority in ways I cannot control.	1	2	3	4	5
3. I know I need to study more, but I cannot find the hours in my schedule.	1	2	3	4	5
4. I waste time on non-essential things when I could be studying.	1	2	3	4	5
5. I start assignments late and run out of time to do them well.	1	2	3	4	5
6. My week rarely goes how I plan it to go.	1	2	3	4	5

YOUR TIME SUBTOTAL

Add the numbers you circled above. Minimum 6, maximum 30.

PART 1 · DIMENSION · METHOD

Study method failure.

RATE EACH FROM 1 TO 5 1 = NOT TRUE 5 = DEEPLY TRUE

1. When I study, I mostly re-read notes or textbook sections.

1 2 3 4 5

2. I highlight key terms and passages as I read.

1 2 3 4 5

3. I make or use flashcards for vocabulary and definitions.

1 2 3 4 5

4. I feel like I am studying, but the material does not stick.

1 2 3 4 5

5. I wait until close to an exam to seriously study.

1 2 3 4 5

6. I spend hours on one topic but cannot explain it afterward.

1 2 3 4 5

YOUR METHOD SUBTOTAL

Add the numbers you circled above. Minimum 6, maximum 30.

PART 1 · DIMENSION · CONTENT

Content gaps.

RATE EACH FROM 1 TO 5 1 = NOT TRUE 5 = DEEPLY TRUE

- | | | | | | |
|--|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. I feel like I am missing foundation concepts from earlier units. | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 2. There are chapters or topics I skimmed that I am now paying for. | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 3. Even when I study, I do not understand the reasoning behind what I am learning. | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 4. Terms blur together and I cannot keep them straight. | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 5. In lectures or exams, other students seem to understand something I do not. | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| 6. I struggle to connect concepts across body systems or units. | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |

YOUR CONTENT SUBTOTAL

Add the numbers you circled above. Minimum 6, maximum 30.

PART 1 · DIMENSION · AFFECT

Affective overload.

These questions ask about shame, panic, and identity. Naming a pattern is not the same as being the pattern. Answer honestly. The pattern is fixable.

RATE EACH FROM 1 TO 5 1 = NOT TRUE 5 = DEEPLY TRUE

1. I feel panic or dread when I think about studying.

1 2 3 4 5

2. I avoid studying even when I have time because it feels overwhelming.

1 2 3 4 5

3. When I get a bad grade, I struggle to open the gradebook for days.

1 2 3 4 5

4. I believe I am not smart enough for this material.

1 2 3 4 5

5. If I cannot study perfectly, I often do not study at all.

1 2 3 4 5

6. I feel ashamed about how far behind I am, and that shame makes it harder to catch up.

1 2 3 4 5

YOUR AFFECT SUBTOTAL

Add the numbers you circled above. Minimum 6, maximum 30.

PART 1 · YOUR PROFILE · SCORES

Write your scores in.

Pencil works best. You will come back to this page.

Transfer your four subtotals into the boxes. The highest is your primary failure mode. The next is your secondary. The lower two are not driving your situation right now. Write them here so you can come back a few Stages in and see how far you have moved.

TIME	METHOD	CONTENT	AFFECT
_____	_____	_____	_____
write 6 to 30	write 6 to 30	write 6 to 30	write 6 to 30

Your profile

Primary failure mode:

The highest score. Address this first.

Secondary failure mode:

The second highest. Often masked by the primary.

Total score:

Add all four subtotals. This gauges your overall acuity.

Total score acuity bands

Stable	24 to 48	Not in crisis. Work on your highest area only. Skim Parts 2 and 3.
Urgent	49 to 72	Run a full Stage for every exam. Start with your primary failure mode.
Critical	73 to 96	Several modes are elevated. Stabilize first. Make your nearest exam your first Stage. Talk to your instructor.
Crisis	97 to 120	Every dimension is elevated. Reach out to campus advising or counseling this week, then begin.

PART 1 · YOUR PROFILE · INTERPRETATION

Write what this means for you.

A score is a number. The interpretation is the work.

My primary failure mode is

Write the name, then what it looks like in your real life right now. Specific examples beat abstractions.

My secondary failure mode is

Be specific. Secondary modes often hide behind the primary.

My acuity band is

Stable, Urgent, Critical, or Crisis. What does it mean for the Stages ahead?

What surprised me

A statement you scored higher or lower than expected. Why?

What I will do first

One sentence. Specific, not aspirational.

PART 1 · WHAT TO DO NEXT

The decision flowchart.

Use your total score and your primary failure mode to find your first move.

START · FIND YOUR TOTAL SCORE



Stable
24 to 48

Work on your highest area only. You may not need the full system yet.

Urgent
49 to 72

Run a full Stage for every exam, in order. Start with your primary failure mode.

Critical
73 to 96

Start now. Make your nearest exam your first Stage. If it is less than two weeks away, keep your focus very narrow.

Crisis
97 to 120

Reach out for support today, campus advising or counseling. Begin your first Stage alongside that.

THEN · WHAT YOUR PRIMARY FAILURE MODE TELLS YOU

Time	Build a realistic study calendar before anything else. In Part 2, lean on the spaced recall schedule.
Method	The most fixable mode. In Part 2, focus on active recall and teach-back. Read Morgan in the Case Library.
Content	Repair foundations selectively, not all at once. In Part 2, use drawing-based synthesis and concept maps. Read Jordan.
Affect	Small, steady action beats a perfect plan. In Part 2, the error log keeps shame off the page. Read Riley.

PART 1 · BEFORE YOUR FIRST STAGE

Stabilize first.

Before you can change anything, you have to see it clearly.

This is where your comeback starts. Before your first Stage, the job is to stabilize: see your situation clearly and make one small set of commitments. In critical care you stabilize the patient before you treat the long-term problem, and this works the same way. You will probably be doing it on your own, and that is fine. That is how it was built.

Your focus right now

Do not try to catch up on the whole course at once. Do not try to rebuild every study habit at once. The goal right now is stabilization, not transformation. Go to class. Turn in what is due. Finish your grade audit and your diagnostic. That is the whole job.

What you will do

- ☐ Finish your grade audit, earlier in Part 1.
- ☐ Take the failure mode diagnostic and score it.
- ☐ Write your interpretation in the book so you can return to it later.
- ☐ Read your result on the decision flowchart.
- ☐ Turn to Part 3 and start your first Stage for your nearest exam.
- ☐ Optional: ask one person to be your weekly check-in partner.

OPTIONAL · WORKING WITH SOMEONE

Most people do this alone, and it works fine that way. But if someone will do it alongside you, a sibling, a friend, a classmate, the whole setup is one 30-minute check-in a week: share your three commitments and be honest about whether you actually did them. They do not even need to be in your course.

PART TWO

How to study.

When your grade can't wait.



PART 2 · YOUR TECHNIQUES

The Recall Toolbox.

Creation is prep. Recall is the gain.

Every technique on the next six pages is a recall technique. Recall is the act of closing the source and retrieving from memory. It is the single study activity that reliably moves a grade.

Most students confuse creation with learning. They write beautiful notes, make detailed concept maps, draw color-coded diagrams. Those are useful, but they are prep work. The moment that moves the grade is the moment you close all of it and try to reproduce it from memory. The blanks are your gaps. The mistakes are your misconceptions.

Every technique that follows is built the same way: a prep step, a recall step, and a check step. Skip the recall step and you have done nothing.

HOW TO SPOT A REAL STUDY TECHNIQUE

Ask one question: where is the recall? If you cannot point to the moment you closed the source and tried to retrieve from memory, you were not studying. You were preparing to study. There is a difference.

PART 2 · THE RECALL TOOLBOX

Drawing-based synthesis.

Given not Googled. Diagram the system from memory.

Why it works

Drawing forces integration. You cannot draw a process whose sequence you do not understand. The blanks are diagnostic; the wrong labels and reversed arrows expose what you only thought you understood. Exams test integration, which is exactly what drawing forces.

The protocol

1 · PREP

Pick one system or process from your current unit, anything with parts and arrows, like the cardiac cycle or an action potential. Glance at the source briefly to load it, then close everything.

2 · RECALL · THIS IS THE GAIN

On the lines below, or a separate blank page, draw the system from memory. Structures, sequence, arrows, labels, connections. Use your own shorthand. Do not stop when you forget. Keep drawing past the gaps.

3 · CHECK

Open the source and compare. Blanks are gaps. Mislabels are misconceptions. Reversed arrows are wrong sequence. Those are your study list. What you drew correctly is retained.

Try it now

Pick one system. Write its name, then draw it from memory on the lines below or on a separate blank page tucked into the book.

PART 2 · THE RECALL TOOLBOX

Active recall (outline–prompted).

The outline asks. Your memory answers.

Why it works

If you write your own questions, you only test what you already know, and the gaps stay invisible. The fix is an outside prompt: the chapter outline, the syllabus, or the learning objectives name what the exam covers. Your memory supplies the answer. That asymmetry is what makes it work.

The protocol

1 · PREP

Open your chapter outline, syllabus, or learning objectives. Read only the named topics, not the content under them. Close everything else.

2 · RECALL · THIS IS THE GAIN

For each topic the outline names, write two or three sentences from memory: what it is, why it matters, how it works. No notes, no textbook, no internet.

3 · CHECK

Open the source. Topics where you wrote nothing are gaps. Wrong answers are misconceptions. Vague answers are thin. Study those three; leave the correct ones alone.

Try it now

List three topics from your current chapter outline. For each, write what you know from memory on the lines below.

PART 2 · THE RECALL TOOLBOX

Teach-back (Feynman).

If you cannot say it, you do not know it.

Why it works

Speaking forces you to turn recognition into production. The textbook can sound familiar; your own explanation cannot pretend. A wall, an empty room, or a houseplant is your audience. None of them feed you the answer. If you stumble or reach for a word you cannot define plainly, you have found a gap.

The protocol

1 · PREP

Pick one concept. Glance briefly at the source to remind yourself which one. Close everything.

2 · RECALL · THIS IS THE GAIN

Out loud, explain the concept as if you were teaching a twelve-year-old. No textbook terms unless you can define them plainly. No notes. Keep talking past the awkwardness. The point is to hear yourself, not to perform.

3 · CHECK

Where did you stumble? Where did you reach for a word you could not define? Those are the gaps. Open the source on those exact points, then teach it back again. The second pass should be smoother.

Try it now

Pick one concept from the Stage you are working on now. Below, write the words you stumbled on or could not define in plain language.

PART 2 · THE RECALL TOOLBOX

Concept maps, with recall.

Build it once. Then close it and build it again from memory.

Why it works

Concept maps are where most students stop and call themselves done. Building the map is prep. The retention happens in the second build, the one you do without looking at the first. Building once is preparing to study, not studying.

The protocol

1 · PREP

With your source open, build a concept map for a unit. Central concept in the middle, branches for sub-concepts, lines between related ideas. Label every connection line with the relationship it represents.

2 · RECALL · THIS IS THE GAIN

Wait at least a day, then hide the first map. On a fresh page, reproduce the whole map from memory: the central concept, the branches you remember, the labeled connection lines. Do not peek.

3 · CHECK

Compare the two maps. Branches you forgot are gaps. Missing connection lines are integration weaknesses. Mislabeled relationships are misunderstandings. That is your study list.

Try it now

Below, sketch a small concept map from memory for one unit: a centre concept, two or three branches, one labeled connection line.

PART 2 · THE RECALL TOOLBOX

Error log + re-attempt.

Every wrong answer is a question you do not yet know how to ask.

Why it works

Logging errors finds patterns, and the patterns are the diagnosis. One wrong answer is noise; ten wrong answers in the same pattern is a fixable weakness. The recall part is the re-attempt: answering the question type again, without notes, a week later. The log alone is record-keeping. The re-attempt is the proof.

The protocol

1 · PREP

For every wrong answer on a practice question or quiz, log four columns: what you thought, what is correct, why you were wrong, what you will remember. One row per error.

2 · RECALL · THIS IS THE GAIN

One week later, attempt the same question, or one of its type, again, without looking at the log. Score yourself.

3 · CHECK

If you got it right on the re-attempt, the entry is closed. If you got it wrong again, it stays open, and your next study session targets that pattern. Read across the log every couple of weeks.

Try it now

Below, log one error from a recent assignment. One sentence per column.

WHAT I THOUGHT	WHAT IS CORRECT	WHY I WAS WRONG	WHAT I WILL REMEMBER

RATHER TYPE IT?

Fill in the error log online, add rows as you need them, then print it.
drsrennie-stack.github.io/STAT/stat-error-log.html

PART 2 · THE RECALL TOOLBOX

Spaced recall schedule.

Pull it from memory four times across two weeks. Do not re-read it four times.

Why it works

This is the one people get backwards. They put a topic on a schedule and then sit and look at it again on each date. Looking is not the point. Producing it from memory is. The brain keeps what it has to work to retrieve, so a few minutes of cold recall on Day 1, Day 3, Day 7, and Day 14 holds far better than an hour of re-reading the night before, and takes less total time.

The protocol

1 · PREP

Choose one topic. Write today's date as Day 1, then work out the Day 3, Day 7, and Day 14 dates and write them next to it.

2 · RECALL · THIS IS THE GAIN

On each date, close every note and book first. For five minutes, produce the topic from memory, out loud or on paper. No peeking. The producing is the whole technique. The looking comes after.

3 · CHECK

Only once you have emptied your memory onto the page, open the source and patch what you missed. Then close it until the next date. Do not stretch the session. The gaps between the dates are doing the work.

Try it now

Below, write one topic and the four dates for your next spaced recall cycle.

TOPIC

Day 1 (today)

write the date

Day 3

write the date

Day 7

write the date

Day 14

write the date

PART THREE

The Stage.

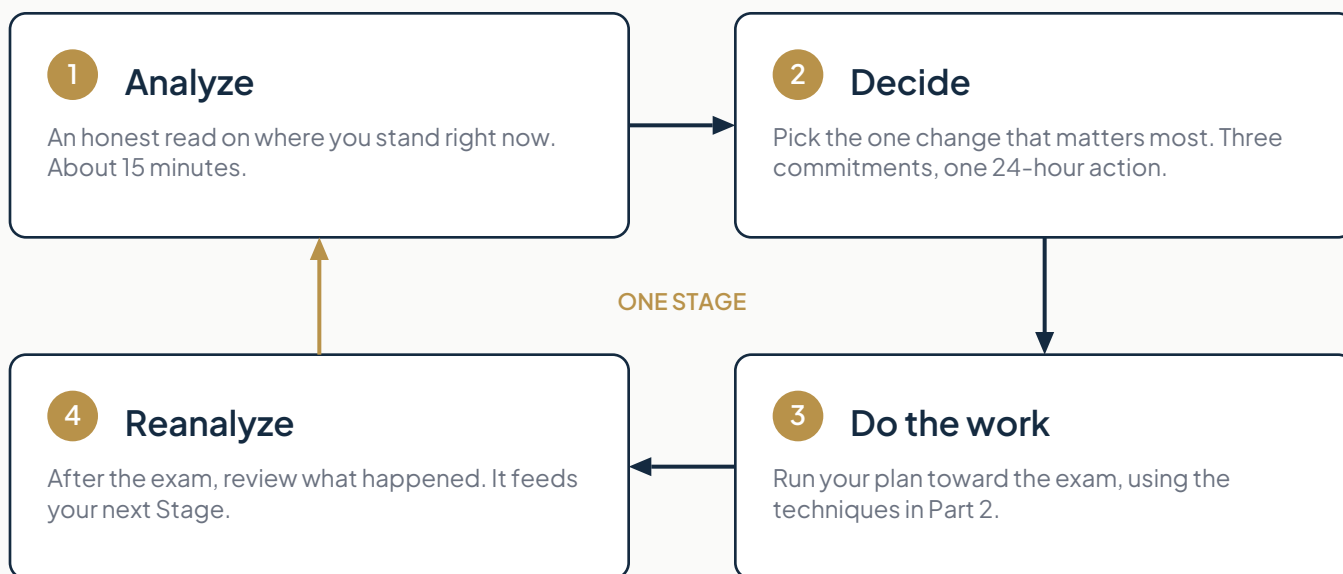
When your grade can't wait.



PART 3 · THE REPEATABLE CORE

How a Stage works.

A Stage is one exam cycle. You run one Stage for every exam in your course. The four steps below are the same every time. Follow the arrows.

**DO THIS ONCE PER EXAM**

Three worksheet pages make up a Stage: Analyze, Decide, Reanalyze. Work one set for every exam in your course. If your course has more exams than the sets printed here, reprint the three pages or use the online versions.

STAGE ONE · STEP 1 · ANALYZE

Analyze.

About 15 minutes. An honest read on where you stand right now. Three questions.

How it feels

How are you feeling about this course right now? Be honest, not polished.

The facts

Your data. Hours studied, topics covered, scores so far, office-hours visits.

The pattern

What do the feelings and the facts add up to? What is the data telling you?

What you see here becomes your plan on the next page.

STAGE ONE · STEP 2 · DECIDE

Decide.

Three commitments. One action for the next 24 hours. One honest prediction.

Three commitments before this exam

1 _____

2 _____

3 _____

One action in the next 24 hours

Concrete, small, immediate. Something you will do today or tomorrow.

Your prediction

How do you expect this Stage to go? What might get in the way?

STAGE ONE · STEP 4 · REANALYZE

Reanalyze.

Right after the exam comes back. Your score is data, not a verdict. Read it honestly.

The result

Your score. What surprised you, good or bad?

Protect

What worked. Keep doing this, whatever the score did.

Pivot

What did not work. This has to change before the next exam.

Add

What the exam showed you was missing from your plan.

What you protect, pivot, and add is where your next Stage begins.

STAGE TWO · STEP 1 · ANALYZE

Analyze.

About 15 minutes. An honest read on where you stand right now. Three questions.

How it feels

How are you feeling about this course right now? Be honest, not polished.

The facts

Your data. Hours studied, topics covered, scores so far, office-hours visits.

The pattern

What do the feelings and the facts add up to? What is the data telling you?

What you see here becomes your plan on the next page.

STAGE TWO · STEP 2 · DECIDE

Decide.

Three commitments. One action for the next 24 hours. One honest prediction.

Three commitments before this exam

1 _____

2 _____

3 _____

One action in the next 24 hours

Concrete, small, immediate. Something you will do today or tomorrow.

Your prediction

How do you expect this Stage to go? What might get in the way?

STAGE TWO · STEP 4 · REANALYZE

Reanalyze.

Right after the exam comes back. Your score is data, not a verdict. Read it honestly.

The result

Your score. What surprised you, good or bad?

Protect

What worked. Keep doing this, whatever the score did.

Pivot

What did not work. This has to change before the next exam.

Add

What the exam showed you was missing from your plan.

What you protect, pivot, and add is where your next Stage begins.

STAGE THREE · STEP 1 · ANALYZE

Analyze.

About 15 minutes. An honest read on where you stand right now. Three questions.

How it feels

How are you feeling about this course right now? Be honest, not polished.

The facts

Your data. Hours studied, topics covered, scores so far, office-hours visits.

The pattern

What do the feelings and the facts add up to? What is the data telling you?

What you see here becomes your plan on the next page.

STAGE THREE · STEP 2 · DECIDE

Decide.

Three commitments. One action for the next 24 hours. One honest prediction.

Three commitments before this exam

1 _____

2 _____

3 _____

One action in the next 24 hours

Concrete, small, immediate. Something you will do today or tomorrow.

Your prediction

How do you expect this Stage to go? What might get in the way?

STAGE THREE · STEP 4 · REANALYZE

Reanalyze.

Right after the exam comes back. Your score is data, not a verdict. Read it honestly.

The result

Your score. What surprised you, good or bad?

Protect

What worked. Keep doing this, whatever the score did.

Pivot

What did not work. This has to change before the next exam.

Add

What the exam showed you was missing from your plan.

What you protect, pivot, and add is where your next Stage begins.

STAGE FOUR · STEP 1 · ANALYZE

Analyze.

About 15 minutes. An honest read on where you stand right now. Three questions.

How it feels

How are you feeling about this course right now? Be honest, not polished.

The facts

Your data. Hours studied, topics covered, scores so far, office-hours visits.

The pattern

What do the feelings and the facts add up to? What is the data telling you?

What you see here becomes your plan on the next page.

STAGE FOUR · STEP 2 · DECIDE

Decide.

Three commitments. One action for the next 24 hours. One honest prediction.

Three commitments before this exam

1 _____

2 _____

3 _____

One action in the next 24 hours

Concrete, small, immediate. Something you will do today or tomorrow.

Your prediction

How do you expect this Stage to go? What might get in the way?

STAGE FOUR · STEP 4 · REANALYZE

Reanalyze.

Right after the exam comes back. Your score is data, not a verdict. Read it honestly.

The result

Your score. What surprised you, good or bad?

Protect

What worked. Keep doing this, whatever the score did.

Pivot

What did not work. This has to change before the next exam.

Add

What the exam showed you was missing from your plan.

What you protect, pivot, and add is where your next Stage begins.

CASE LIBRARY

The Case Library.

Seven students. Seven patterns. Read the one that sounds like you.

CASE LIBRARY · HOW TO USE IT

Find your case.

Seven students, seven failure patterns. Read the ones that sound like you.

Each one is a student working to turn their own grade around. You can think clearly about someone else's situation in a way you cannot yet manage for your own. That is the point. Start with the case that sounds most like you.

Morgan**STUDY METHOD**

Studies hard, the wrong way.

Jordan**CONTENT GAPS**

Method fixed, foundations missing.

Alex**MIXED RESULTS**

Some scores up, some flat. Reading the data.

Riley**AFFECTIVE LOAD**

The work is paying off, but it does not feel like it.

Sam**HIDDEN TEST ANXIETY**

A diagnosis that was right, but incomplete.

Casey**TRIAGE**

Too much to cover, too little time.

Taylor**MAKING IT LAST**

It worked. Now make it stick.

CASE LIBRARY · STUDY METHOD

Morgan's case.

The student who studies harder than anyone they know, and is failing anyway.

CASE SNAPSHOT

Course	Anatomy & Physiology 2
Weeks into the semester	4 of 16
Current grade	58%
Exams completed	2 of 5 (56%, 38%)
Lab practicals	2 of 5 (38%, 58%)
Hours studied / week	15 to 18
Office-hours visits	0

Morgan, in their own words

I do not understand what is happening. I study harder than anyone I know. My notes are beautiful, color-coded by system. I reread the chapters before lectures and again before exams. But when I sit down for the exam, my mind goes blank. I leave feeling like I did not know half of what was asked. I am starting to wonder if I am just not smart enough for nursing.

What is actually happening

- Reads each chapter with a highlighter before lecture.
- Takes handwritten color-coded notes during lecture.
- Rewrites notes after class.
- Re-reads textbook sections in the days before each exam.
- Uses flashcards for vocabulary almost daily.
- Watches recommended videos, sometimes twice.
- Has not attended a single office-hours session.

WHAT THIS CASE SHOWS YOU

Morgan is doing passive review. Every activity on Morgan's list feels like studying and produces almost no retention. The hours are real. The work is not.

CASE LIBRARY · CONTENT GAPS

Jordan's case.

The student who fixed their method, and is still failing.

CASE SNAPSHOT

Course	Anatomy & Physiology 2
A&P 1 grade	C-minus
Current grade	62%
Lecture exams	3 of 5 (65%, 60%, 61%)
Lab practicals	2 of 5 (58%, 55%)
Hours studied / week	18 to 22
Office-hours visits	1

Jordan, in their own words

I did the work. I stopped rereading. I got rid of the color-coded notes. I bought a practice question bank and I actually use it. I self-test without notes. And yet the exam last week was a 61. When I try to explain the resting membrane potential out loud, I cannot do it. It is like the professor is building a house and everyone else has the foundation already, and I am standing on sand.

What is actually happening

- Switched from passive re-reading to active recall.
- Uses a practice question bank almost daily.
- Self-tests without notes.
- Attended one office-hours session.
- Studies more hours, more efficiently.
- Cannot explain core concepts out loud when asked.

WHAT THIS CASE SHOWS YOU

Jordan no longer has a method problem. Jordan has a foundation problem. A better method cannot fix missing prerequisites. The work here is to find them and close the most critical ones, selectively.

CASE LIBRARY · MIXED RESULTS

Alex's case.

The exam came back. The results are mixed. Now what?

CASE SNAPSHOT

Course	Anatomy & Physiology 2
Grade four weeks ago	52%
Current grade	62%
Exam lecture score	68% (up from 51%)
Exam lab practical	54% (essentially flat)
Hours studied / week	20 to 24

Alex, in their own words

My lecture score jumped seventeen points. I should feel good. But the lab practical barely moved. The method change worked for lecture. It did not transfer to lab. I do not know whether to celebrate the lecture jump or panic about the practical.

What is actually happening

- Lecture exams climbing: 48, 51, 65, 68.
- Lab practicals flat: 42, 48, 54.
- Foundation work helped lecture, not lab.
- Studying mostly in one modality, read and recall.

WHAT THIS CASE SHOWS YOU

Most real exam results are mixed. The work is honest reading, without celebration or despair. Apply Protect, Pivot, Add. The method that worked for lecture is not the method that will work for the lab practical. Lab is a different modality and needs different practice: specimen-based, spatial, hands-on.

CASE LIBRARY · AFFECTIVE LOAD

Riley's case.

The intervention is working. Riley is about to quit anyway.

CASE SNAPSHOT

Course	Anatomy & Physiology 2
Starting grade	56%
Current grade	61%
Most recent exam	64% (up from 48%)
Final exam weight	30%
Weeks until the final	3

Riley, in their own words

I have done everything you said. I switched to active recall. I am sleeping more, studying less but better. And my grade went up five points. Five. I have a final worth 30% in three weeks. Even if I get a 90% on it, I might still fail. I do not know if I can keep doing this for three more weeks if it might not be enough.

What is actually happening

- Study sessions feel different: 45 minutes of focus versus 15 at the start.
- Recall is happening without effort.
- Anxiety is lower: seven hours of sleep before the midterm versus three before.
- Study-partner sessions are productive.
- A sixteen-point jump on the midterm versus the previous exam.
- Riley is reading only the course grade as the signal.

WHAT THIS CASE SHOWS YOU

Riley is in the middle of a comeback. The work is paying off and the early signs are obvious. But Riley is watching only the slow signal, the course grade, and reading it as proof that nothing is working. Quit now and Riley walks away from a comeback that has already started. The fix is to make the early signs visible, starting with Riley's own eyes.

CASE LIBRARY · HIDDEN TEST ANXIETY

Sam's case.

The method is better. The scores are not. A differential diagnosis.

CASE SNAPSHOT

Course	Anatomy & Physiology 2
Starting grade	52%
Current grade	55%
Midterm score	58%
Starting diagnosis	Method failure
Hours studied / week	20 to 22

Sam, in their own words

I am studying better than I have in my entire college career. I can recall things. I can explain things. I went into the midterm feeling actually prepared. And I got a 58%. So why are my scores still terrible? I knew the answer to question 12. I just blanked. My mind went somewhere else and I could not get back. That happened five times.

What is actually happening

- Method has objectively improved.
- Study sessions are sharper.
- Recall in low-stakes practice is strong.
- On exams: blanking, shallow breathing, hands shaking, time disappearing.
- Sam mentioned these symptoms in three of five audits.
- None appeared in the first diagnostic, because Sam did not know to flag them.

WHAT THIS CASE SHOWS YOU

The first diagnosis was right, but incomplete. Test anxiety was masked by the obvious method failure. A better method alone cannot solve test anxiety. The next move needs different tools: practice under exam-like conditions, breathing protocols, possibly counseling support. Re-read your own diagnostic and look for what it missed. Revising your plan partway through is not failure. It is information.

CASE LIBRARY · TRIAGE

Casey's case.

Fourteen days. Twelve chapters. Seven mastered. The math of triage.

CASE SNAPSHOT

Course	Anatomy & Physiology 2
Starting grade	51%
Current grade	60%
Midterm score	67% (up from 50%)
Final exam weight	30%
Days until the final	14
Chapters mastered	7 of 12

Casey, in their own words

I have actually done the work. But I look at the syllabus for the final and I see twelve chapters and I have basically not touched five of them. I cannot study five chapters from scratch while also reviewing the seven I know. Part of me wants to spread my time evenly. Another part wants to triple down on what I know. Both feel wrong.

What is actually happening

- Method, foundation, and study-partner work are paying off.
- Mastery on 7 of 12 final-exam chapters.
- The five un-studied chapters include three of the four highest-weighted topics.
- The seven mastered chapters include three of the lowest-weighted topics.
- Casey has not yet looked at the topic weighting.

WHAT THIS CASE SHOWS YOU

Casey's answer is sitting in the syllabus. The triage answer is not study evenly or abandon the five. It is study the highest-weighted topics first, whichever list they came from. The three highest-weighted topics are in the unstudied five, which makes them the priority. Triage asks where an hour of study earns the most points, not where it feels best to spend it.

CASE LIBRARY · MAKING IT LAST

Taylor's case.

The program worked. The plan for after is what makes it stick.

CASE SNAPSHOT

Course	Anatomy & Physiology 2 (second attempt)
Starting grade	47%
Final score	72%
Course grade	71%
Starting diagnosis	Affective crisis
Next semester	A&P lab, anatomy, microbiology

Taylor, in their own words

I passed. That feels strange to type. I have not passed an A&P course before. I do not know which parts I figured out for real and which parts were just the structure of being in this program every week. What happens when I am alone again.

What is actually happening

- Method changes are likely to survive without effort.
- The weekly self-audit will need deliberate maintenance.
- The accountability structure will fade unless replaced.
- Shame, low self-efficacy, and anticipatory anxiety did not resolve. They stabilized.
- Stabilized, not transformed.

WHAT THIS CASE SHOWS YOU

A weak plan for after is just "I will keep doing what I have been doing," and that is how people slide back. A strong one is specific: what structure to replace, what habits to keep, what signals would call you back. Write the strong version. And notice what Taylor actually did, which was stabilize, not transform. That is plenty. Even an outcome worse than Taylor's can be worked again, because a failed class is a delay, not an ending. The one thing you cannot come back from is deciding you are the failure. So do not decide that. The data is never all the way in.

PART FOUR

After STAT.

When your grade can't wait.



PART 4 · WHAT SURVIVES

Make it stick.

20 to 30 minutes. The last worksheet, and the one that decides whether any of this lasts.

When a patient leaves the hospital, what keeps them well is not the treatment. It is the plan for after. The same is true here. When the workbook ends, its structure ends with it, and the habits it was holding up can quietly go too. So before you close it, decide what replaces it.

A Likely to survive without effort

Habits that now feel like the default. Going back to the old way would feel wrong.

B Will need deliberate maintenance

Habits that work, but only because you keep them on a schedule. They fade if you do not protect them.

C Will fade unless you replace the structure

Habits that depended on something external: this workbook, a partner, a deadline. Name the replacement now.

IF YOU TOOK ON A CHECK-IN PARTNER

If you set up a weekly check-in partner back in Triage, this is the moment to make it permanent. A 30-minute weekly check-in that survived the whole workbook is the strongest replacement structure you can build.

SCAN TO USE ONLINE**Make it stick (online)**

The same three-category worksheet online, so you keep a saved record to come back to next semester if the warning signs show up.



SCAN FOR DIRECT ACCESS

PART 4 · THE HAND-OFF

A comeback is not prevention.

The skills that got you out of the hole are not the same skills that keep you out of it.

Working a failing course and working a healthy one are two different jobs. A comeback is the rescue. Prevention is staying well afterward. Stay in rescue mode once the crisis is over and you will burn out, so the first thing to know is which job you are doing now.

COMEBACK MODE

WHEN YOU USE IT

Below goal. Time short. Urgent or Critical.

WHAT YOU COVER

Highest-weight, weakest topics. Let the rest go.

WHERE TIME GOES

A few topics, hit hard. Cut the rest.

HOW YOU STUDY

Active recall, nothing else. Drop what does not stick.

WHAT YOU WATCH

Did the grade move? Are you stable yet?

WHAT WINNING IS

You pass. You are still standing for the next class.

PREVENTION MODE

At or above goal. Time normal. Stable.

Everything assigned, at real depth.

Across the whole syllabus, with room to explore.

Active recall, plus discussion and synthesis.

Can you teach it? Can you connect it?

You finish strong and carry it into the next course.

THE HAND-OFF

Right now you are between the two. The plan on the last page is the bridge. Keep the comeback habits that turned out to help even when nothing was on fire, and add back the steady prevention habits you set aside during the crisis.

PART 4 · WHEN TO COME BACK

Warning signs.

Name three signals that would tell you to open this workbook again.

Academic trouble rarely lands overnight. It usually builds for two to four weeks before it ever reaches a transcript. The whole skill is spotting it early, before it shows up in the gradebook. Name the three signs that would tell future you the wheels are coming off, and write down what you will do the moment you see each one.

1 Warning sign 1

When I see this, I will:

2 Warning sign 2

When I see this, I will:

3 Warning sign 3

When I see this, I will:

YOU ARE ALLOWED TO COME BACK

Opening this workbook again is not a failure. It is a monitoring system doing its job. The students who fall the hardest are the ones who refuse to restart, because they treated the first comeback as a one-time event. It is not. It is a skill, and you will use it more than once.

TEAR-OUT · THE WHOLE METHOD ON ONE PAGE

Quick reference.

Everything the workbook teaches, on one page. Tear it out.

THE STAGE · RUN ONE PER EXAM

Analyze	An honest read on where you stand: how it feels, the facts, the pattern.
Decide	Three commitments and one action for the next 24 hours.
Do the work	Run your plan toward the exam with the Recall Toolbox.
Reanalyze	After the exam: Protect, Pivot, Add. It starts your next Stage.

THREE ACUITIES

■ Stable	B range or better, more than 4 weeks out, broad confidence.
■ Urgent	C range, 2 to 4 weeks out, specific gaps.
■ Critical	At or below passing, under 2 weeks out, broad uncertainty.

FOUR FAILURE MODES

Time	Scarcity. The hours are not there.
Method	Passive review. Hours without retention.
Content	Foundation gaps blocking current material.
Affect	Anxiety, shame, avoidance, low self-efficacy.

SIX RECALL TECHNIQUES

Drawing synthesis	Close the source. Diagram the system from memory.
Active recall	Outline prompts, memory answers, then check.
Teach-back	Say it to a wall. If you cannot, you do not know it.
Concept maps	Build once with the source. Rebuild later from memory.
Error log	Log the wrong answer. Re-attempt it a week later.
Spaced recall	Day 1, 3, 7, 14. Five minutes from memory, each.

MEDMASTERS COLLABORATIVE

When your grade can't wait.

*Failure is what happened.
It is not who you are.*

Bring the workbook. Bring your honesty. Bring your refusal to fail quietly. The rest is method.

COMPANION TOOL HUB



drsrennie-stack.github.io/STAT/hub.html

Dr. Sharilyn Rennie

Professor of Anatomy & Physiology
Founder and Learning Architect, MedMasters Collaborative